

The Last Bus

DIFFICULT PRACTICE

Name: _____ Date set: _____ Due: _____

OPENING — CONTINUE FROM HERE

The doors hissed shut behind me before I'd even found a seat, and for a moment the whole bus rocked with the force of it. Every other passenger had somewhere obvious to be — headphones in, eyes down, the particular stillness of people who have done this journey a thousand times. I hadn't. I'd got on because it was the only bus still running, and because the alternative was standing outside that house a minute longer than I already had.

Three stops later, someone sat down directly across the aisle from me and didn't look away.

— *continue the story from this exact moment* —

You are not starting from nothing. Match the voice and tense already set (first person, past tense) and keep it consistent throughout. Whatever happens next has to make sense of two things the opening already tells us: something happened at "that house," and someone on this bus already recognises the narrator.

YOUR WRITING

CHECKLIST — GO OVER IT AGAIN

1. Build tension gradually — don't reveal who the stranger is or what happened at the house too early.
2. At least one short, punchy sentence at a moment of realisation, and one line of internal thought showing fear or suspicion.
3. Give the stranger one distinguishing detail that becomes significant later, and resolve the "house" mystery by the end.
4. **Tense and person stay consistent** — first person, past tense, throughout, including flashback moments.
5. Every "he/she/they" clearly refers back to a named character — no ambiguous pronouns.
6. **No unearned twist** — if the stranger turns out to be significant, the reader should be able to look back and see it was fair, not random.
7. Ending resolves or meaningfully changes the tension set up in the opening — it doesn't just stop.